

The Aztec emperor Moctezuma was fearful of the Spanish, aware of their military reputation and ruthlessness. He placated them with gifts and housed them in a palace in his island capital. The Spanish were also wary, as they were now effectively prisoners. Cortés launched the desperate scheme of taking Moctezuma prisoner, though

this simply encouraged the Aztecs who were hostile to the Spanish presence to chose another leader.

Tenochtitlán began its descent into chaos when Cortés's soldiers massacred a large number of young Aztec nobles taking part in a festival of feasting and dancing. As the city rebelled, Moctezuma proved powerless to calm the Aztecs; he was stoned by his own people and later died of his wounds. Cortés fought his way out of the city, losing three-quarters of his men in the disastrous "Night of Sorrows." However, the Aztecs failed to deliver the death blow to Cortés's bedraggled survivors. Boosted by large numbers of new soldiers attracted by rumors of huge wealth, and by a vast auxiliary army of native peoples anxious to throw off the yoke of Aztec dominance, Cortés undertook a second, and this time definitive, siege of Tenochtitlán, forcing the Aztecs into a final surrender after a desperate struggle in August 1521. While Cortés set about organizing his new territory, others



Inca Gold Armlets

Gold jewelry in the Inca empire was a sign of wealth and power. Gold was also used for ceremonial items.

were exploring to the south. Birú excited the Spanish, who sent an expedition along the Pacific coast in 1522 that found no gold but confirmed reports of a rich empire inland. Further expeditions continued to map the coast, and two of these were led by Francisco Pizarro, an illiterate but

brave 51-year-old soldier.

In 1527 Pizarro landed at Tumbes, an Inca outpost (see pp.210–13), trading goods for gold, silver, jewels, and cloth. With this treasure, he returned via Panama to Spain

and sought permission to mount an armed expedition.

By 1531 he was back with three ships and 180 men. Reaching Tumbes, he found it ruined by a civil war between Atahualpa (see right) and his brother Huáscar for control of the Inca empire. Learning that Atahualpa and his army were across the mountains at Cajamarca, Pizarro, with his 106 footsoldiers and 62 horsemen, set out on a trek to meet Atahualpa. They were received by an imperial envoy bearing gifts from the emperor, who was camped with his army outside the city. Pizarro lured Atahualpa into Cajamarca, took him hostage, and was offered an enormous ransom. With the treasure amassed by July 1533, and panicked at rumors of an Inca counterattack to liberate Atahualpa, Pizarro and his officers executed the emperor. The Spanish then marched on the capital, Cuzco, and seized control of the entire Inca empire.

An uneven struggle

Both Aztec and Inca empires fell to remarkably small Spanish armies. But the Spanish had guns, horses, and armor, and ruthlessly exploited their opponents' weakest points: the repressive rule of the Aztecs over their subject peoples, and the Inca civil war. From a strategic point of view, they

LAST INCA EMPEROR (1502–33)

ATAHUALLPA

Atahualpa came to power after a bloody civil war that broke out on the deaths of both his father, Huayna Capac, and the probable heir to the throne by 1527.

Atahualpa took charge of the imperial army in Quito while his half-brother Huáscar ruled the city of Cuzco. The civil war that broke out between these two for the throne tore the empire apart. By the time Atahualpa triumphed in 1532, the Spanish had already invaded Inca territory.



recognized that both empires were highly centralized states ruled over by all-powerful emperors. Capture the emperor and the state was paralyzed. Following the conquest, the Spanish exploited the religion of the Aztecs, using their desire for captured enemies to sacrifice to turn them into allies on the battlefield. Pizarro was also helped by the superb Inca road network that enabled his troops to cross otherwise inaccessible terrain. Perhaps most importantly, though, the Spanish brought with them diseases to which the Americans had no resistance. Diseases decimated local populations as the Spanish took control of their lands. In everything but numbers, the Spanish had the advantage and the luck.

◀ The capture of Tenochtitlán

The destruction of the Aztec capital by Cortés in 1521 is shown in this somewhat fanciful late 18th-century painting by an unknown Spanish artist. The splendor of the city on its island in Lake Texcoco is clear, though not, perhaps, the brutality of the conquest.

▽ Inca storehouses

The Incas were great stonemasons, building depots to store their harvested crops, and roadside hostels for royal messengers and other travelers.



AFTER

The arrival of Europeans in force on the American mainland had lasting consequences on all sides.

CONTINUED RESISTANCE

Spanish conquest of Central and South America did not end with the fall of the two main empires. The **last Inca stronghold** fell to the Spanish in 1572, and the Inca hinterland was largely untouched until the early 1800s. Conquest of the Aztecs and Central America was more complete,

but the Maya were a greater challenge, as their states had to be conquered one by one.

NEW FOOD

Other than gold and silver **234–35** >> the Spanish discovered and subsequently exported many new plants, such as tobacco, and foodstuffs. In return, the Europeans introduced a variety of crops, livestock, and diseases **236–37** >>.



TOBACCO